

Creature: Shade of the Lost (Malicious Dread Hunter)

Description: The Shade of the Lost is a nightmarish, spectral beast that appears as a grotesque wolf wreathed in swirling shadows and dripping with dark, sinister energy. Its elongated form is unnaturally twisted, with elongated limbs and a maw filled with razor-sharp teeth that seem to whisper promises of despair. Its eyes burn with a hellish green fire, reflecting the souls of the dwarves it has devoured, and its growl reverberates like the tolling of a death knell. As it moves, the shadows seem to writhe and pulse with a life of their own, amplifying the sense of dread it exudes.

Abilities:

- **Incorporeal Movement:** The Shade can pass through solid objects and creatures as if they were difficult terrain, taking 5 (1d10) force damage if it ends its turn inside an object.
- **Malicious Hunger:** The Shade can detect dwarves within 120 feet, sensing their fear and despair. It has advantage on attack rolls against dwarves. When it hits a dwarf with its Soul Drain ability, it deals an additional 21 (6d6) necrotic damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 16 Constitution saving throw or be poisoned until the end of its next turn.
- **Wail of Despair:** As an action, the Shade can unleash a terrifying wail that echoes with the cries of the dwarves it has consumed. Each creature within a 60-foot radius must make a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 36 (8d8) psychic damage and is frightened for 1 minute. A frightened target must use its action to Dash away from the Shade on each of its turns. A successful save halves the damage and prevents the frightened condition.
- **Shadow Pounce:** If the Shade moves at least 30 feet straight toward a creature (preferably a dwarf) and then hits it with a bite attack on the same turn, that target must succeed on a DC 17 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone and take an additional 21 (6d6) necrotic damage.
- **Soul Drain:** Melee Attack: +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 30 (6d10) necrotic damage, and the Shade regains hit points equal to the damage dealt. If the target is a dwarf, the Shade can force the target to make a DC 17 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, the target's maximum hit points are reduced by the amount taken until a long rest, and they suffer one level of exhaustion.
- **Aura of Eternal Despair:** Any creature that starts its turn within 15 feet of the Shade must succeed on a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw or be overwhelmed by a deep sense of hopelessness, gaining one level of exhaustion. Additionally, they are unable to regain hit points until they leave the aura.
- **Shadow Mimicry:** As a bonus action, the Shade can create an illusory duplicate of itself that lasts for 1 minute. This duplicate can mimic the Shade's appearance but cannot attack or take damage. The duplicate can move and act independently, causing confusion and fear. Creatures that attack the illusion must make a DC 16 Wisdom saving throw or take 7 (2d6) psychic damage as their attack fails.

Lore: The Shade of the Lost is a dark reflection of the malevolence that festers within the hearts of the forsaken. It is said to be born from the anguish and regrets of dwarves who have died in sorrow or despair. This creature delights in the torment of its prey, hunting down dwarves with an insatiable hunger for their life force and their very souls. It revels in the agony of its victims, using their fear to grow even more powerful.

Combat Strategy: The Shade of the Lost is cunning and malevolent, using its speed and shadowy nature to stalk its prey. It will first deploy its Wail of Despair to scatter enemies and instill terror. Then, it uses its Shadow Pounce and Soul Drain to eliminate isolated dwarves, feeding off their despair. The Shade will strategically use its Shadow Mimicry to confuse foes and manipulate the battlefield, delighting in their fear and pain as it hunts them down.

Lore of the Shade of the Lost (Malicious Dread Hunter)

The **Shade of the Lost** is a horrifying manifestation of vengeance and malevolence, born from the blood-soaked grounds of ancient battlefields where dwarves once fought valiantly against their foes. In the wake of their slaughter, the spirits of these fallen warriors were twisted by their rage and despair, giving rise to this ferocious creature that thrives on the very essence of fear.

For centuries, the Shade has haunted dwarven strongholds, stalking the shadows and feeding on the dread of those it targets. It is said that its presence heralds doom, and when it appears, it is accompanied by a chilling silence that suffocates the air. The Shade's appetite is insatiable, particularly for the souls of dwarves, whom it views not just as prey but as trophies to be claimed.

In the dead of night, it prowls the outskirts of dwarven settlements, waiting for the unwary. With a sinister growl, it lunges at its victims, tearing into them with its razor-sharp fangs, reveling in the warm blood that spills forth. The Shade delights in the sounds of despair, listening to the screams of the fallen as it drags them into the depths of the shadow realm, where they are consumed in a never-ending torment.

Once a dwarf has fallen into its grasp, the Shade uses its Soul Drain ability not only to devour their life force but also to extract their memories and fears. It delights in reliving the moments of regret and sorrow, amplifying the anguish it causes. Victims may find themselves trapped in an endless cycle of torment, forced to relive their worst fears as the Shade feasts on their terror.

The Shade of the Lost is not simply a hunter; it is a sadistic tormentor. It has been known to toy with its prey, allowing them a fleeting glimpse of hope before snuffing it out completely. As it hunts, it leaves a trail of devastation in its wake—once-proud dwarven communities lie in ruin, their inhabitants lost to madness and despair, haunted by the Shade's insidious whispers.

This malevolent entity thrives on the chaos it creates, seeking out the most vulnerable dwarves and exploiting their fears. It whispers dark promises of vengeance to those who have suffered

betrayal or loss, luring them into a false sense of security before striking with brutal force. The Shade's ultimate goal is to create a landscape of despair, where it reigns supreme as the embodiment of fear and anguish.

In stories told around flickering campfires, the Shade of the Lost is described as a relentless force, a dark harbinger that will stop at nothing to extinguish the last flickers of hope from the hearts of the dwarves. It is a creature born of violence, feeding on the darkness that festers within, and its reign of terror seems destined to continue until the last remnants of dwarven bravery are snuffed out.